

How to Start a Career with Open Source Skills

In this second article on career choices and job opportunities, we look at the advantages of starting a career by contributing to open source.

There are many boot camps and guides out there trying to sell you courses that will launch your career in technology.

They promise to teach you valuable skills that are critical to marketing yourself as a great programmer. Interestingly, most of them focus on building your open source programming portfolio by means of hands-on projects. In this article, let's explore what exactly it is that makes open source projects so important, and how you can launch your career by leveraging your OSS capabilities.

Evaluating technical expertise

There's a famous story about Elon Musk selling a game he developed as a teenager for about US\$ 500. There are

stories claiming that Mark Zuckerberg started coding when he was 12 and created an internal network for his family called Zucknet; and that Bill Gates and Larry Ellison famously sold software they hadn't even completed building, to their enterprise consumers. A common theme among these titans is a keen understanding of the technology they peddled to make their millions. Back then, it was enough for them to

be able to speak authoritatively about the technicalities of their product offerings to be able to generate interest from the consumers and investors.

Today, with the learning curve for tech no longer being as steep, the game has changed. Working demos are now a prerequisite; and slides often don't suffice. For individuals, demonstrating domain expertise is even more challenging today, given the need for concrete evidence of their talents. In a market where millions have ideas, with thousands actively pursuing them and hundreds having the networks that can get them an audience with the best agencies, it becomes incredibly difficult to tell the substance from the fluff without concrete proof-of-concept. The same analogy extends to recruitment, which seems to have undergone a massive paradigm shift into a structured process of elimination, especially for mass-recruitment of talent.

How has recruitment changed?

From being referred by a cousin's friend to his uncle's company, to actually being



Figure 1: Open source software has changed the world (source: K2 Data Science)